

STANDARD ENGLISH CONVENTIONS

Sentence boundaries

Find the clauses. Choose the connection.

First move: Identify the subject and main verb on each side of the blank. Decide which parts can stand alone.

1 Complete or incomplete?

An **independent clause** expresses a complete thought. A **dependent clause** cannot stand alone.

COMPLETE The team analyzed the samples.
FRAGMENT Although the team analyzed the samples.

Words such as *although*, *because*, *if* and *when* can make a clause dependent.

Trap: A long group of words can still be a fragment.

2 Find the main verb

An **-ing form** or **infinitive** alone does not supply a clause's main verb.

FRAGMENT The scientist studying the fossils.
COMPLETE The scientist **is studying** the fossils.
COMPLETE The scientist studying the fossils **found** an error.

Trap: A verb inside a relative clause may not complete the main clause: "The scientist *who found the fossil* smiled."

3 Connect two ideas correctly

Connection	Rule	Example
Period	Two complete sentences.	The trial ended. Analysis continued.
Semicolon	Two related independent clauses.	The trial ended; analysis continued.
Comma + FANBOYS	Joins two independent clauses.	The trial ended, but analysis continued.
Colon	Complete clause → explanation, example or list.	The trial had one flaw: a small sample.
Single dash	Can introduce an emphatic addition or explanation.	The trial had one flaw—a small sample.

FANBOYS: for · and · nor · but · or · yet · so

"However" is not FANBOYS

The trial ended; **however**, analysis continued.
The trial ended. However, analysis continued.
The result, **however**, was unexpected.

The word's position determines its punctuation.

Dependent-clause order

Because it rained, the match stopped.
The match stopped **because it rained**.

An introductory adverbial clause takes a comma. An essential one following the main clause usually does not.

Eliminate these: "The trial ended, analysis continued" is a comma splice. "The trial ended analysis continued" is a run-on. Use a valid boundary.

Three qualifications: A colon's explanation may be a phrase; a semicolon joining clauses needs complete clauses on both sides. A contrasting final clause may take a comma: "They continued, although it was difficult." A noun clause used as the subject takes no separating comma: "What they found was surprising."

STANDARD ENGLISH CONVENTIONS

Commas, pronouns & possession

Keep the sentence connected. Make every reference clear.

1 Essential or extra?

Essential: identifies which one; no enclosing commas.

Students **who submitted essays** received feedback.

Nonessential: adds information about an already identified noun; set it off.

The students, **who all submitted essays**, received feedback.

Check: Deleting extra information must preserve the intended reference.

2 Match enclosing marks

Enclose an insertion with matching commas, dashes or parentheses.

The novel, **published in 1920**, is popular.
The novel—**published in 1920**—is popular.
The novel (**published in 1920**) is popular.

Match any punctuation already supplied.

Names and titles depend on their role

The physicist **Wu** led the study.
Wu, **a physicist**, led the study.

3 Keep the grammatical core intact

No lone comma between...	Correct example
Subject and verb	The discovery of new species was significant .
Verb and object; preposition and object	They studied fossils . They focused on fossils .
Two simple verbs sharing one subject	They collected samples and analyzed them .

Valid enclosed insertion: "The team, **after a delay**, returned."

4 Lists and adjectives

List: reading, writing, and math.

Pair: reading and writing.

Complex list: semicolons separate items containing commas.

Lima, Peru; Quito, Ecuador; and Bogotá, Colombia.

Coordinate adjectives: reverse their order or insert *and* to test for a comma.

a careful, thorough analysis
a large stone building (*no comma*)

5 Pronoun checks

Match the noun's number and person. Keep the reference clear.

The **device** is old, but **it** works.
The **devices** are old, but **they** work.

Subject: "She and I analyzed the data."

Object: "The tutor spoke to her and me."

Check: Remove the other person: "to me." Singular *they* is valid when context permits.

6 Possession or contraction?

Meaning	Form	Do not confuse
One owner	the student's essay	its = possession; it's = it is / it has
Plural owners ending in s	the students' essays	whose = possession; who's = who is / who has
Irregular plural owners	the children's books	their = possession; they're = they are
Ordinary plural	several students	there = location, or "there is / there are"

Fast check: Expand contractions. *Its*, *yours*, *hers*, *ours*, *theirs* and *whose* take no apostrophe.

STANDARD ENGLISH CONVENTIONS

Verbs, modifiers & parallelism

Find the true subject. Follow the timeline. Align the parts.

1 Subject-verb agreement

Watch for...	Correct example	Reason
Intervening nouns	The collection of books is valuable.	<i>Collection</i> is singular.
<i>Along with / as well as</i>	The teacher , along with the students, is ready.	The added phrase does not make the subject plural.
<i>Each / every / everyone</i>	Each of the experiments has a control.	<i>Each</i> is singular.
Distinct subjects + <i>and</i>	The poet and the painter are collaborating.	Two people: plural.
<i>Either...or / neither...nor</i>	Neither the teacher nor the students are ready.	Agree with the nearer subject.
Subject after the verb	On the shelf are two books .	Find the actual subject.
<i>A number / the number</i>	A number of students are absent. The number of students is rising.	Several students versus one count.

2 Tense follows time

Time	Example
Habit / general fact	The device measures pressure.
Finished past event	They tested it in 2024.
Past connected to now	They have used it since 2024.
Earlier than a past point	By the time testing began, they had repaired it.

Justified shift: "She completed the course last year and now teaches it."

Trap: *For* and *since* do not dictate tense: "She studied **for three hours yesterday**" is correct.

4 Attach the modifier correctly

The subject after an opening participial phrase should be the person or thing described.

WRONG Born in 2004, computers fascinated Maya.
RIGHT Born in 2004, **Maya** was fascinated by computers.

Position changes meaning:

"**Only Maya** read the report" limits who.
"Maya read **only the report**" limits what.

3 Check the whole verb phrase

Perfect: has/have/had + past participle.

Progressive: a form of *be* + *-ing*.

Passive: a form of *be* + past participle.

She **has written** the report.
She **is writing** the report.
The report **was written** by her.

Passive voice is valid. Decide whether the subject performs or receives the action.

Trap: An *-ed* form can modify a noun: "The device *tested yesterday* **works**." Here, *works* completes the main clause.

5 Match grammatical structures

WRONG reading, to write, and debating

RIGHT reading, writing, and debating

Align paired structures: "not only **accurate** but also **efficient**."

Compare like with like

Maya's results were clearer than **Leila's**.
Compare results with results, not with a person.

Agreement routine: Remove descriptive phrases temporarily → find the subject → choose the verb → restore the sentence and check meaning.

INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Reading: claims & evidence

Answer the exact question. Support every part of your choice.

Reading routine: Read the question → identify the task → paraphrase the relevant idea → check every claim in the answer.

1 Central ideas and details

Main idea: capture the whole passage's central point, including its limits.

PASSAGE A new material is cheap to produce, but its durability is uncertain.

MAIN IDEA The material offers a cost advantage, although its long-term performance is unclear.

Detail: find the specific information requested. Correct answers often paraphrase the text.

Reject: one minor detail presented as the main idea; an answer that is only partly supported.

2 Inferences

Choose the conclusion most strongly supported by the text. Avoid adding assumptions.

EVIDENCE A sensor worked in laboratory tests. Outdoor performance has not been tested.

SUPPORTED Its outdoor effectiveness remains uncertain.

UNSUPPORTED It will be ineffective outdoors.

Match certainty: *may* is not *will*; *some* is not *all*. Strong wording is fine only when supported.

3 Support or weaken a claim

State the exact claim before comparing evidence.

Support: makes it more credible.

Weaken: challenges its prediction, explanation or assumption.

CLAIM The treatment improves plant growth.

SUPPORT In a well-controlled experiment, treated plants grew more than untreated plants.

Trap: Related to the topic does not mean relevant to the claim. Check the direction requested.

4 Literary evidence

Find words or actions that demonstrate the stated interpretation.

CLAIM A character is reluctant to leave.

EVIDENCE The character delays packing and repeatedly asks to stay.

Keep the narrator's, speaker's and characters' views separate.

Trap: A quotation mentioning the character does not necessarily show the claimed attitude.

5 Tables and graphs

Read the **title, labels, units, groups and time period**. Make the comparison requested, then connect it to the claim.

Illustrative data: seeds germinated (%)

Group	Day 3	Day 7
Control	30	60
Treatment	50	80

Compare the same day or the same group across days.

Supported: On day 7, treatment exceeded control by 20 percentage points.

Unsupported: The treatment rate doubled from day 3 to day 7. It rose from 50% to 80%, not 100%.

Data traps: Highest ≠ greatest increase. Percent ≠ percentage points. Association alone does not establish causation. Do not extrapolate beyond the data without support.

Final question: Which exact words or values support the whole answer?

CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Reading: meaning & purpose

Use context. Identify function. Keep authors' positions separate.

1 Words in context

Predict a simple meaning. Check meaning, tone, intensity and grammar.

Far from permanent, the arrangement was _____, lasting only two weeks.

PREDICT Temporary; short-lived.

Trap: The usual meaning may not fit: a *qualified endorsement* is approval with reservations.

2 Use context clues

Clue	Look for...
although; however	Contrast or an unexpected relationship.
because; therefore	Reason and consequence.
for example; such as	A concrete illustration.
A nearby definition	A paraphrase of the meaning.

Reject: wrong meaning, wrong intensity, or contradiction elsewhere in the text.

3 Overall purpose

Identify what the author aims to do: explain, compare, challenge, describe, or introduce.

Topic: Bird migration.

Purpose: Explain how new tracking data challenged an earlier account of migration.

Trap: Naming the topic alone does not explain the purpose.

4 Structure and function

Name the sentence's role: evidence, example, definition, contrast, or qualification.

"The sample was small" may **qualify a conclusion** drawn from a study.

Trap: An answer can correctly summarize a sentence without explaining its role.

5 Cross-text connections

Summarize each author's position separately. Identify the requested agreement, disagreement, qualification, or likely response.

Text 1	Text 2
Remote work can improve productivity by reducing interruptions.	Remote work can improve productivity, but some collaborative tasks benefit from in-person work.

Supported relationship: Text 2 qualifies Text 1's positive view. It does not wholly reject it.

Track each author

Attribute claims correctly. Partial agreement is not total agreement. Different emphasis need not mean disagreement.

Literature and older language

Identify speaker, events and attitude. Paraphrase unusual syntax. Read across poetic line breaks when sentences continue.

6 Common wrong-answer patterns

Too broad or too narrow

Unsupported cause

Wrong author

Wrong degree of certainty

True detail, wrong task

Answer test: Put vocabulary choices back into the sentence. For purpose or function, name the action and its object: "challenges an earlier explanation"

EXPRESSION OF IDEAS

Transitions & rhetorical synthesis

Name the relationship. Read the goal. Select what matters.

1 Choose the logical transition

Name the link first. Similar topics alone do not establish the relationship.

Relationship	Typical transitions	Meaning
Addition	moreover; furthermore; in addition	Another supporting point.
Similarity	similarly; likewise	A comparable pattern.
Contrast / concession	however; nevertheless; even so; by contrast	A difference or unexpected outcome.
Consequence	therefore; consequently; as a result	A result that logically follows.
Example / detail	for example; for instance; specifically	A particular case or precise detail.
Restatement	in other words; that is	The same idea clarified.
Sequence / time	subsequently; previously; meanwhile	Later, earlier or simultaneous.
Emphasis	indeed; in fact	Reinforcement or confirmation.

Addition: "The treatment was expensive. **Moreover**, it produced no measurable benefit." Both ideas are drawbacks.

Precision matters: *Nevertheless* = despite that; *instead* = replacement or alternative; *conversely* = reversal.

2 Let the goal choose the notes

Read the goal first. Select accurate information that fulfils it and suits the audience.

Goal	What the answer needs
Show a similarity or difference	Compare both subjects on the same relevant feature.
Introduce a person or work	Give enough identifying context and the relevant contribution.
Give an example	Choose a specific case that illustrates the general claim.
Describe a finding or significance	State the relevant result or importance, supported by the notes.

Notes

- Arlen survey: 240 bird species.
- Bexley survey: 175 bird species.
- Both used acoustic monitoring.

Goal: emphasize a similarity

Both surveys used acoustic monitoring to record bird species.

The totals are accurate but unnecessary for this goal.

Two checks: Is every claim accurate? Does it fulfil the goal? Accurate but irrelevant information does not work.

3 Before choosing an answer

- ☐ Answer the exact question.
- ☐ Check the whole sentence or claim.
- ☐ Match scope and certainty.

- ☐ Use evidence.
- ☐ Shortest is not always best.
- ☐ Explain why your choice works.

Scope: [College Board Reading & Writing](#). Rule checks: Purdue OWL [punctuation](#), [commas](#), [tense](#), [passive voice](#). Original teaching examples.